S04-L5 — Graduation: The Advisor's Own Pitch

Summary. This lesson closes out week four's block of lessons by applying to Virginia herself the pitch structure the course taught for presenting an artwork, history, comparables, and a justification for the moment. The central argument does not rest on taste or personality, it rests on verifiable evidence about the house where she works and about her own professional conduct. The note develops two distinct and complementary strands of evidence, Phillips's structural position among the three major auction houses and the auction records the house holds for specific Latin American artists despite its smaller scale, and contrasts them with the model of an independent advisor, to show that neither strand of evidence substitutes for the other.

1. Presenting oneself with the same discipline as a work of art

This week's previous lesson formalized a two-minute pitch in three fixed parts, history, recent comparables, and a justification for why the present moment favors the transaction. That structure does not depend on the object being presented. When a client asks an advisor why they should work with that particular person, they are asking for the same kind of reconstructible evidence they would ask for regarding an artwork's price, not a statement of intentions. The literature on commercial practices in the art market documents that same principle from the seller's side, Dylan Lessel, co-director of Perrotin Second Marché, described how his team assembles a file with auction results and price comparables before communicating any valuation, so the client can reconstruct how the number was reached rather than accepting it on blind trust.[1] Carried over to an advisor's own track record, the principle demands the same thing, offering verifiable data about one's professional standing instead of a simple claim of competence.

2. Phillips's scale, and a record that does not follow scale

Phillips is, of the three major auction houses operating in New York, the smallest by annual volume. With the final 2025 results, Sotheby's brought in roughly 7.5 times what Phillips did, and Christie's roughly 6.7 times, a ratio that held stable relative to 2024.[2] That scale gap, already covered in the course's first week, describes a structural difference between the three business models, not a single year's fluctuation.

Total scale, however, does not determine who holds a given artist's auction record. Brazilian sculptor Lygia Clark, a central Neo-Concrete figure covered in week two of the course, holds her auction record at Phillips New York, where her piece *Bicho invertebrado* sold on November 21, 2013 for USD 1,865,000.[3] Colombian sculptor Doris Salcedo, whose Art Icon designation from the Whitechapel Gallery was covered in the previous lesson, also holds her auction record at Phillips, with an *Untitled* work that sold for USD 665,000.[4] Neither record depends on Phillips competing in volume with Christie's or Sotheby's, it depends on the house having been, at the moment of those sales, the meeting point between that specific work and the buyer willing to pay that price.

A second data point, from a different segment of the business, adds to that evidence. In its Editions department, where works start in the low thousands, Phillips states that 41% of its buyers during 2025 were new clients to the house.[5] The figure describes a commercial structure built to bring in collectors who are just starting out, a relevant argument for a client who is evaluating for the first time which advisor and which house to build a long-term relationship with.

3. The independent contrast: conduct as evidence apart from scale

Institutional evidence, however, does not exhaust what a client needs in order to trust an advisor. The case of Evan Tawil, an independent art advisor and private dealer who operates without the backing of any large house, shows a different kind of evidence. Tawil described his private client roster growing mainly through referrals, sustained by four concrete practices, responding quickly, communicating from the start what he can and cannot resolve, ruling out an unviable request early rather than stringing it along with false expectations, and avoiding renegotiating an agreement once it's closed.[6] None of those four behaviors depends on an organization's scale, they depend entirely on how the person acts toward the client in each concrete moment of the relationship.

4. The limit: institutional evidence does not substitute for demonstrated conduct

The error this lesson works to prevent is treating a house's prestige or scale as a sufficient substitute for individual professional conduct, or treating individual conduct as a sufficient substitute for institutional backing. The Clark and Salcedo records, and the Editions new-buyer figure, are evidence that Phillips's infrastructure delivers verifiable results. Tawil's four practices are evidence that an advisor's responsibility toward a specific client is not automatically delegated to the name of the house where they work. A complete professional pitch needs to show both kinds of evidence, and promising them without sustaining them afterward in practice costs the relationship more than never having mentioned them.

For the client conversation

First, when a client asks why to work with a particular advisor and not another at the same house or a different one, the professional answer offers verifiable evidence about the institution and about one's own conduct, not a description of personal qualities. Second, a house's scale and a given artist's record are two different questions, and it's worth not using one to answer the other in front of an informed client. Third, an advisor can reasonably cite the infrastructure of the house they work at as evidence of results, as long as it comes paired with concrete, time-verifiable conduct commitments, of the kind documented in independent advisors' practice.

Notes

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1. Talking Galleries, *Barcelona Symposium 2022*, interview with Dylan Lessel, Perrotin Second Marché, 2022-10-03/04. Talking Galleries. ↩
2. Sotheby's, "Sotheby's Projects 2025 Consolidated Sales of $7 Billion" (2025-12-17), Sotheby's; Phillips, 2025 global results release (2025-12-18), Phillips. ↩
3. Phillips, results release for the Latin America sale, New York, November 2013. Phillips. ↩
4. Phillips, Doris Salcedo artist page, auction results. Phillips. ↩
5. Phillips Editions, 2025 buyer data. Phillips. ↩
6. Artnet News, '*Honesty Saves Time*'*: Why Top Collectors Come to Advisor Evan Tawil*, 2023-10-20. Artnet. ↩